

Umpire Report – Bushey CC 3rd XI v West Herts CC 5th XI

To: Herts Cricket League Disciplinary Committee

Dear Sir/Madam,

I wish to formally report a number of serious disciplinary incidents that occurred during the match between **Bushey CC 3rd XI and West Herts CC 5th XI**, where I stood as one of the appointed umpires.

Throughout the fixture I experienced sustained abuse, intimidation and repeated challenges to my authority as an umpire. In my opinion, the conduct of a number of Bushey CC players, led primarily by their captain, **Mr P. Sivatharman**, was wholly unacceptable and contrary to both the **ECB General Conduct Regulations** and the **Spirit of Cricket**.

Incident 1 – Boundary Decision (Ball 5.3)

On ball **5.3**, I clearly observed the ball cross the painted white boundary line and immediately signalled **Four** to the scorers.

Immediately after making this signal, several Bushey fielders converged on me to challenge the decision. Rather than respectfully asking for clarification, I was subjected to personal accusations. The Bushey captain, **Mr P. Sivatharman**, repeatedly referred to me as being "**dishonest**" and a "**cheat**."

Mr H. Wahid was particularly vocal, repeatedly calling me a "**cheat**" and insisting that the decision on whether the ball had reached the boundary should be made by the fielders rather than the umpire.

The discussion lasted for approximately **ten minutes**, during which I was surrounded by several members of the fielding side and subjected to sustained verbal abuse.

In an effort to restore order and allow the match to continue, I reluctantly rescinded my original decision and reduced the award from **four runs to three runs**.

I wish to make it absolutely clear that I did **not** change this decision because I believed it was incorrect. From my position as umpire, I remained satisfied that the ball had crossed the painted boundary. The decision was altered solely because the Bushey players refused to accept the umpire's decision and the game could not progress.

Incident 2 – Abuse Following Wide Decision (Ball 12.2)

On **ball 12.2**, I called and signalled **Wide**.

Immediately after making this decision I was subjected to personal abuse, including being told to "**Fuck off**" and being referred to as a "**prick**."

I was again accused of "**cheating**."

I responded calmly by saying:

"Please respect the umpire's decision, as West Herts had done whilst they were fielding."

Despite this, the dissent continued and the abuse did not stop.

Incident 3 – Illegal Bowling Action (Ball 21.6)

During **Mr S. Ahmed's** spell I became increasingly concerned regarding the legality of his bowling action.

From my position as umpire, I observed on several deliveries that his bowling arm appeared to remain bent through the point of release, with the ball appearing to be thrown or "chucked" rather than delivered with a legal overarm bowling action.

A legal delivery requires that once the bowling arm reaches shoulder height it must not be straightened prior to releasing the ball (subject to the permitted tolerance under the Laws of Cricket).

Before taking formal action, I spoke privately to Mr Ahmed on **two separate occasions**, explaining my concerns and warning him that unless the action changed I would have no alternative but to call **No Ball**.

Despite these warnings, I remained of the opinion that the action had not materially changed.

Accordingly, on **ball 21.6**, I called and signalled **No Ball** for an illegal bowling action.

Once again, this resulted in significant dissent and confrontation from members of Bushey CC, who openly disputed the decision and challenged my authority.

Incident 4 – Intimidation of the Square Leg Umpire

The square leg umpire during this innings was one of West Herts' opening batters, a **15-year-old volunteer**, performing umpiring duties in accordance with normal club cricket practice.

Following my No Ball decision, I sought confirmation from the square leg umpire, who independently confirmed that he had observed the same illegal bowling action. Both umpires were therefore in agreement.

Rather than accepting the decision, several Bushey players surrounded the **15-year-old square leg umpire**, challenging him aggressively and speaking to him in a disrespectful and intimidating manner.

I found this particularly concerning given his age and the fact that he was volunteering to assist in officiating the match.

Ironically, earlier in the same over, **Mr P. Sivatharman** had instructed me that I should **not be having discussions with his players**. However, moments later, multiple Bushey players collectively challenged both myself and the young square leg umpire over the same decision.

This behaviour was entirely inconsistent with the captain's own instruction and, in my opinion, demonstrated a complete disregard for the authority of both umpires.

Summary

I have been involved in club cricket for **over eight years** as both a **Club Manager** and **umpire**, during which time I have officiated **more than 300 cricket matches** across junior and adult cricket. I have managed highly competitive league fixtures, cup finals and emotionally charged matches, yet I have **never** experienced the level of abuse, intimidation and disrespect that I encountered during this fixture.

Throughout the afternoon I was repeatedly called a **"cheat"**, accused of being **"dishonest"**, referred to as a **"prick"**, told to **"fuck off"**, and had virtually every significant decision challenged by multiple Bushey players. At no stage did the captain meaningfully intervene to stop this behaviour. Instead, it appeared to be tolerated and, at times, encouraged.

As an umpire, I fully accept that players may respectfully question decisions or seek clarification. That is part of the game. What occurred during this match was fundamentally different. The repeated attacks were not directed at my decisions alone; they were direct attacks on my **integrity, honesty and character**. Being repeatedly labelled a **"cheat"** and **"dishonest"** is deeply offensive and personally upsetting to someone who volunteers countless hours to support grassroots cricket.

What concerns me most is that the persistent pressure placed upon me appeared to achieve the outcome Bushey CC desired. Every significant decision that was challenged ultimately resulted in an outcome favourable to Bushey CC in order to allow the game to continue. The boundary at **5.3** was reduced from four runs to three despite my continued belief that it had crossed the boundary. Following the illegal bowling action, the delivery was re-bowled after prolonged confrontation. No umpire should ever feel compelled to compromise simply because one side refuses to accept an umpire's decision.

Equally concerning was the treatment of the **15-year-old volunteer square leg umpire**, who was subjected to similar intimidation simply for confirming what he had independently observed. I consider this wholly unacceptable and entirely contrary to the Spirit of Cricket. Young volunteers should be encouraged and protected, not intimidated.

I believe the conduct displayed during this match falls significantly below the standards expected by the Hertfordshire Cricket League and the ECB. If behaviour of this nature is not robustly addressed, there is a real risk that volunteer umpires and young officials will be discouraged from officiating, ultimately damaging grassroots cricket.

Finally, I wish to advise the League that there are **three separate safeguarding concerns** relating to the conduct of **Mr P. Sivatharman** that I believe require independent consideration. As these matters are distinct from the disciplinary incidents outlined above, I will submit them under separate correspondence.

Yours faithfully,

Prad Kanuga
Match Umpire